

China AI chip

Key takeaways from WAIC 2026: China's AI infrastructure shifts

Following our two-day visit to WAIC 2026, we believe China's AI infrastructure ecosystem has demonstrated a decisive shift from single-chip benchmarking to system-level deployment, and from capacity build-out to a genuine token economy. Our key takeaways are: 1) delivering single-chip performance at effective Hopper-class level has become the baseline, while Prefill/Decode-disaggregation architectures have moved from experimental to standard; 2) super-node solutions spanning dozens to thousands of cards have emerged as the critical system-level answer to process-node constraints, explicitly targeting trillion-parameter model deployment; and 3) making AI compute affordable and ubiquitous is the driving force, but deployment requires sustained ecosystem co-innovation. Our top picks within the ramping indigenous AI supply chain are Iluvatar CoreX, JCET, NAURA, and AMEC.

- **The baseline of chip performance has reset to Hopper-class.** Even though domestic AI chip vendors remain focused on solving near-term capacity and supply bottlenecks, we believe the next imperative is delivering effective Hopper-class compute by late this year and into 2027. For instance, Iluvatar CoreX launched its Tiangai 300 chip, which claims 10-20% superior performance versus Hopper architecture on selective inference metrics. The PD-disaggregation paradigm has become a well-recognized cost-reduction mechanism for LLM inference at scale, confirming inference as the proven commercial application for domestic GPUs. Training is now widely viewed as the next scalable and critical market.
- **Extensive showcase of super-node solutions.** The most significant architectural development we noted at WAIC 2026 was the emergence of super-nodes as the industry's answer to two structural constraints: the ceiling on domestic process nodes and the arrival of trillion-parameter LLMs (e.g., Kimi K3's 2.8-trillion-parameter architecture). To overcome single-chip boundaries given the inferior absolute performance of local AI chips, super-nodes serve as unified compute domains, employing different approaches to chip-to-chip interconnection, switch/fabric design, and software across the ecosystem. Liquid cooling, optical interconnects, and orthogonal cabinet architectures are likely to become the minimum requirements rather than differentiators for next-generation deployments.
- **Transforming AI tokens into workforce.** Agentic AI has emerged as the key application-layer force reshaping infrastructure demand going forward, as agents functioning as digital proxies consume tokens at rates several orders of magnitude higher than human users, creating an exponential demand curve. We believe the promotion of the token factory concept in China represents a deliberate industrialization strategy aimed at making AI tokens affordable and ubiquitous across numerous

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real-world applications. However, the ecosystem remains immature in critical dimensions such as industry standards for heterogeneous scheduling, token quality measurement, and the optimal super-node scale (ranging from dozens to thousands cards) across different verticals, in our view.

- **Stock implications.** We believe Iluvatar CoreX (OW) is best positioned among tier-2 AI chip players, backed by secured supply and design wins at top CSP customers. Additionally, we expect back-end service providers to benefit from increasing demand for advanced packaging and testing, thus we favor JCET (OW). We are also positive on the WFE sector, underpinned by strong capex for memory and advanced logic fabs, and NAURA (OW) and AMEC (OW) are our preferred names.

Companies Discussed in This Report (all prices in this report as of market close on 20 July 2026, unless otherwise indicated)

AMEC - A(688012.SS/Rmb342.50/OW), Iluvatar CoreX - H(9903.HK/HK\$495.20[17 July 2026]/OW), JCET - A(600584.SS/Rmb76.99/OW), NAURA - A(002371.SZ/Rmb676.91/OW)

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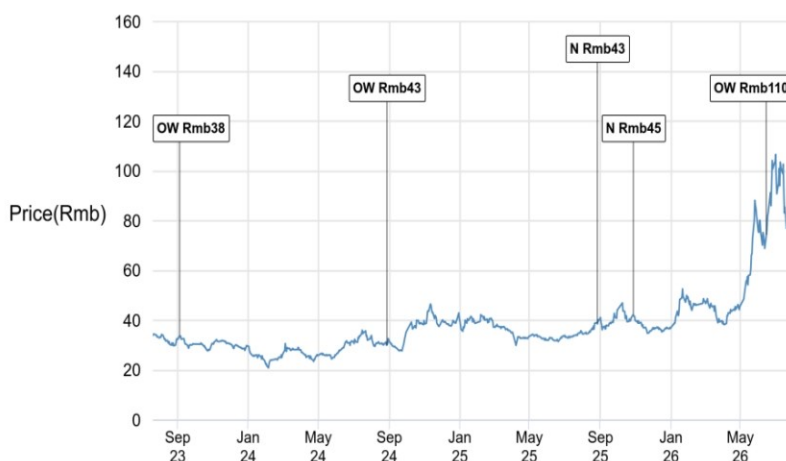
Iluvatar CoreX - H (9903.HK, 9903 HK) Price Chart



Date	Rating	Price (HK\$)	Price Target (HK\$)
07-Apr-26	OW	219.80	620
28-Jun-26	OW	684.00	920

Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P. and J.P. Morgan; price data adjusted for stock splits and dividends.
Initiated coverage Apr 07, 2026. All share prices are as of market close on the previous business day.

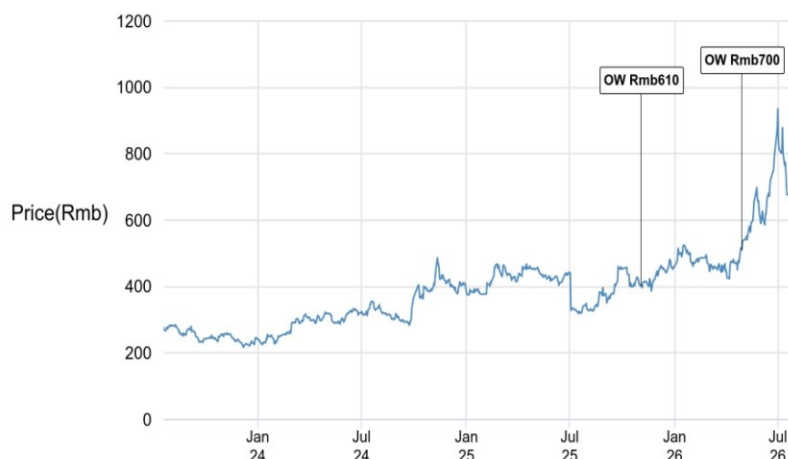
JCET - A (600584.SS, 600584 CH) Price Chart



Date	Rating	Price (Rmb)	Price Target (Rmb)
05-Sep-23	OW	33.62	38
28-Aug-24	OW	30.10	43
27-Aug-25	N	38.99	43
28-Oct-25	N	42.09	45
16-Jun-26	OW	74.32	110

Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P. and J.P. Morgan; price data adjusted for stock splits and dividends.
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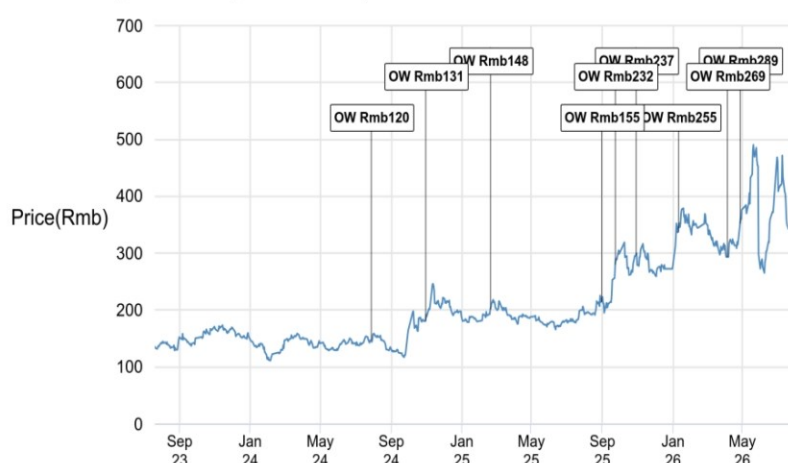
NAURA - A (002371.SZ, 002371 CH) Price Chart



Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P. and J.P. Morgan; price data adjusted for stock splits and dividends.
Initiated coverage Nov 04, 2025. All share prices are as of market close on the previous business day.

Date	Rating	Price (Rmb)	Price Target (Rmb)
04-Nov-25	OW	401.00	610
30-Apr-26	OW	510.71	700

AMEC - A (688012.SS, 688012 CH) Price Chart



Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P. and J.P. Morgan; price data adjusted for stock splits and dividends.
Initiated coverage Jul 29, 2024. All share prices are as of market close on the previous business day.

Date	Rating	Price (Rmb)	Price Target (Rmb)
29-Jul-24	OW	146.78	120
31-Oct-24	OW	181.15	131
20-Feb-25	OW	201.27	148
31-Aug-25	OW	214.17	155
24-Sep-25	OW	280.00	232
30-Oct-25	OW	296.66	237
11-Jan-26	OW	336.68	255
06-Apr-26	OW	293.50	269
28-Apr-26	OW	352.01	289

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